The Abui Language

Marking the patient on the verb

Francis Bond
with thanks to George Saad

2026

Overview

1. The Abui Language
2. Marking the Patient on the Verb
3. Summary

Outline

1 The Abui Language

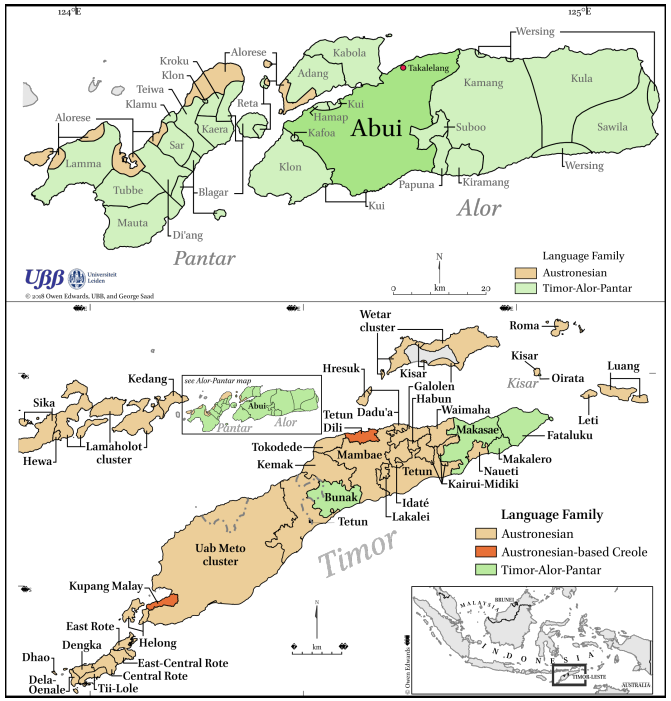
2 Marking the Patient on the Verb

3 Summary

Abui

- Spoken on Alor Island, eastern Indonesia
- About 41,000 speakers
- Timor-Alor-Pantar family: **Papuan**, not Austronesian (Kratochvíl, 2007)
- Endangered: in contact with the lingua franca Alor Malay
- Word order agent–patient–verb (≈ SOV)
- Lots of verbal morphology, as we will see





Outline

1 The Abui Language

2 Marking the Patient on the Verb

3 Summary

Who Did What to Whom?

Every language has to show who is the doer and who it is done to

- **A** (agent): the one who acts
- **P** (patient): the one acted upon
- English and Indonesian use word order: *the dog bit the man*
- Abui puts a prefix on the verb that points to the patient

(1) Na a-ruidi.
1SG.AGT 2SG.PAT-wake.up.PFV
"I woke you up." [abz]

- The agent **na** "I" is a separate word
- The patient **a-** "you" is glued to the verb

Examples from Klamer and Kratochvíl (2018), who cite Kratochvíl (2007, 2014) and the Abui corpus. AGT agent pronoun, PAT patient prefix, PFV perfective

Not One Set of Prefixes but Five

	PAT	LOC	REC	BEN	GOAL
I (1SG)	na-	ne-	no-	nee-	noo-
you (2SG)	a-	e-	o-	ee-	oo-
he, she, it (3)	ha-	he-	ho-	hee-	hoo-

The vowel tells you, roughly, what role the patient plays

- PAT *a*: directly affected ("I woke you up")
- LOC *e*: the location of the action
- REC *o*: a recipient ("laughed at me")
- BEN *ee*: a beneficiary ("hit it for you")
- GOAL *oo*: a goal ("poking me")

Table after Klamer and Kratochvíl (2018, Table 5); distributive and plural rows omitted.

The Prefix Hints at the Role

(2) Ma na ee-bol.
be.PROX 1SG.AGT 2SG.BEN-hit
“Let me hit [it] for you.” [abz]

(3) Simon di noo-dik.
Simon 3AGT 1SG.GOAL-prick
“Simon is poking me.” [abz]

But this is only the easy part: most of the time the choice of prefix is not predictable from the meaning alone

Differential: Sometimes There Is No Prefix at All

Differential object marking: the patient is marked only some of the time, depending on what kind of thing it is

- Compare Spanish: *veo la casa* "I see the house" but *veo a Juan* "I see Juan"

(4) Di kanai do bol took.
3AGT pili.nut PROX hit drop
"He was hitting pili nuts (and) dropping [them]." [abz]

(5) Baloka ne-toku he-bol he-balasi ba ...
k.o.grass 1SG.POSS-leg 3.LOC-hit 3.LOC-beat.PFV SIM
"The baloka grass hit my legs, slashing them ..." [abz]

- Nuts (inanimate): no prefix on *bol* "hit"
- My legs (part of a living being): prefix *he-*

Same Verb, Different Prefix: Living or Not

(6) Maama, na mahiting he-puna yo!
father 1SG.AGT meat 3.LOC-hold.IPFV MD.AD
"Father, I will hold the meat (while you slice it)!" [abz]

(7) Di noo-puna!
3.AGT 1SG.GOAL-hold.IPFV
"He is grabbing (groping) me!" [abz]

- Holding meat: LOC prefix
- Holding a person: GOAL prefix
- Both are marked, but differently: a **symmetric** alternation

Same Verb, Different Prefix: How Much Does It Change?

(8) Di kawen ha-komangdii.
3.AGT machete 3.PAT-make.blunt.PFV
"He made the knife blunt." [abz]

(9) Di kawen he-komangdii.
3.AGT machete 3.LOC-make.blunt.PFV
"He made the knife blunter." [abz]

A test: can you add "... but it is still sharp"?

- After PAT *ha-*: no, the knife is completely blunt
- After LOC *he-*: yes, it only changed a bit

PAT marks a patient that is **fully affected**; LOC one that is affected less (Kratochvíl and Delpada, 2015)

A Whole Family of Pairs

verb	PAT *ha-*: fully affected	LOC *he-*: less affected
-kol	*ha-kol* "tie it up"	*he-kol* "tie it"
-kuya	*ha-kuya* "expose it"	*he-kuya* "peel it"
-lilri	*ha-lilri* "boil it"	*he-lilri* "warm it up"
-dik	*ha-dik* "pierce it"	*he-dik* "stab at it"
-taang	*ha-taang* "give it away"	*he-taang* "pass it along"
-bel	*ha-bel* "pull it out"	*he-bel* "pluck it"
-lak	*ha-lak* "destroy it"	*he-lak* "demolish it"

- One Abui verb, two prefixes, often two English verbs
- The pattern holds for verbs of change: cooking, cutting, moving, destroying

From Kratochvíl and Delpada (2015, 222–228), as cited in Klamer and Kratochvíl (2018)

Some Verbs Never Alternate

About one verb in ten always takes PAT *ha-*, whatever the meaning

ha-weel	"wash him, bathe him"
ha-fik	"pull it, pull him"
ha-balak	"punch him"
ha-al	"burn it"

- The prefix is fixed by the verb's **inflectional class**, not by the event (Fedden et al., 2014)
- Like gender in French or German: you learn it with the word
- Possibly an older layer of the language, from before the *ha-*/*he-* contrast became systematic

Outline

1 The Abui Language

2 Marking the Patient on the Verb

3 Summary

P-Indexing in Abui Is Differential and Complex

- Abui transitive verbs can index the patient with a prefix, but not the agent
- Whether a prefix appears, and which one, depends on
  - the verb itself (some verbs never alternate)
  - animacy: is the patient a thing, an animal, a person?
  - affectedness: is the patient fully or only partly changed?
  - also volition, definiteness and specificity (Kratochvíl, 2011, 2014)
- Five main prefix paradigms, plus zero marking; the full system has more
- Here we focused on the most frequent 3rd person forms

To describe this you need thousands of recorded examples, which is why the Abui corpus matters

Acknowledgements and References I

Thanks to George Saad for sharing his slides, on which this summary is based



Sebastian Fedden, Dunstan Brown, František Kratochvíl, Laura C. Robinson, and Antoinette Schapper. 2014. Variation in pronominal indexing: Lexical stipulation vs. referential properties in the Alor-Pantar languages.

Studies in Language, 38(1):44–79.



Marian Klamer and František Kratochvíl. 2018.

The evolution of differential object marking in Alor-Pantar languages.

In Ilja A. Seržant and Alena Witzlack-Makarevich, editors, *Diachrony of Differential Argument Marking*, number 19 in Studies in Diversity Linguistics, pages 69–95. Language Science Press, Berlin.



František Kratochvíl. 2007.

A Grammar of Abui: A Papuan Language of Alor.

LOT, Utrecht.

Acknowledgements and References II



František Kratochvíl. 2011.

Transitivity in Abui.

Studies in Language, 35(3):588–635.



František Kratochvíl. 2014.

Differential argument realization in Abui.

Linguistics, 52(2):543–602.



František Kratochvíl and Benidiktus Delpada. 2015.

Degrees of affectedness and verbal prefixation in Abui (Papuan).

In *Proceedings of the 22nd International Conference on Head-Driven Phrase Structure Grammar*, pages 216–233, Stanford, CA. CSLI Publications.